Book Review

Reviewer: Chelsea Cooper
Book Name: Influence: Science and Practice (5th Edition)
Author(s): Robert B. Cialdini
Year Published: 2009

Author's argument (or perspective) and summary of the content:

Dr. Robert Cialdini is a Professor Emeritus of Psychology and Marketing at Arizona State University and President of "Influence at Work," a consulting, strategic planning and training organization focused on strengthening skills of influence. His clients have included Coca Cola, Google, Microsoft, Cisco Systems, Bayer, and the United States Department of Justice. Cialdini is also author of Influence: the Psychology of Persuasion and Yes! 50 Scientifically proven ways to be persuasive. He is one of the most widely recognized experts on persuasion and influence in the United States.

In this book, Cialdini argues that we are living in a fast paced world with many competing demands on our analytical capabilities. Often, instead of using all relevant available information, we use "fixed action shortcuts" to make decisions. These shortcuts allow us to make decisions based on generalizations, which requires less thought, analysis, and time. Cialdini refers to this as a "Click, whirr" or automatic response. Cialdini asserts that there are six key psychological principles that influence human behavior: reciprocation, consistency, social proof, liking, authority, scarcity.

These types of response may make it easier for us to make quick decisions in a complex environment, but they can be exploited by influence professionals. Cialdini cautions us to guard against compliance practitioners who try to profit from the mechanical nature of shortcut responding. He says that "we should be willing to use boycott, threat, confrontation, censure, tirade, nearly anything, to retaliate."

In the book, Cialdini devotes a chapter to explain each of the 6 key principles in-depth. The book is structured sort of like a text book, and is rich with vignettes, scientific studies, illustrations, and commentary. In each chapter, in addition to describing the compliance principle and strategies, Cialdini shares tips for defending against those strategies if they are directed against you.

The six key principles include the following:

1) Reciprocation: This is the idea that if someone gives or does something for us, we are then obligated to repay them. By first doing us a favor, people we might not otherwise find likeable can increase the chances that we will comply with their requests, and we are more willing to purchase products that we would not otherwise have purchased. Examples include Hare Krishnas giving small gifts and then asking for donations, household cleaning companies leaving samples, etc. Cialdini mentions the "Rejection-then-retreat" strategy of making a large request, and then when a person refuses, making a smaller, more manageable request. The person will likely view the smaller request as a concession on the part of the requestor, and then feels inclined to make a concession of their own and accept the smaller request. Researchers have found that the "rejection-then-retreat" strategy can lead to increased likelihood not only that the person will agree to a desired request, but will also increase the likelihood that the person will carry out the request (behavior) and volunteer to perform additional future requests. Cialdini states that "a person who feels responsible for the terms of a contract will be more likely to live up to that contract."

2) Consistency: This refers to the idea that humans desire to be consistent with their prior commitments and actions. Once we make a choice, we feel compelled to behave in a way that is consistent with that prior commitment. The author provides an example of a study where people who were asked and agreed to watch someone's belongings at the beach were much more likely to chase after someone stealing a radio from the beach blanket than those who had not agreed to watch the belongings. It is the commitment that's critical. By securing a commitment from someone to do something, they are more likely to do it than those who have not committed. Research has shown that asking voters whether they will commit to going to the polls for an election actually contributes to increased turnout on election day. The author describes a "Foot-in-the-door" technique where you can present small trivial requests and then once someone has agreed, present additional larger requests (example of putting small decal for a social cause in the window and then later agreeing to put a very large sign in the front yard). Cialdini explains that agreeing to trivial requests can actually shift our self image. Commitment decisions can be self perpetuating and agreeing to trivial requests can actually shift our self image (i.e. from bystander to social issues activist or engaged citizen) and we begin to see benefits of the behaviors that go beyond those immediately presented. The book discusses "the committing power of written statements," explains that public commitments tend to be stronger and more lasting than private ones, and says that those who go through a great deal of trouble or pain to attain something tend to value it more highly than people who attain the same thing with minimal effort. The author mentions that the commitment factor of social influence may be especially powerful in individualistic societies, and less so in more communal cultures.

3) Social Proof: This relates to the idea that we determine how to behave by finding out what other people think is correct or appropriate. When we see others performing a behavior, we tend to view the behavior as correct or appropriate for that situation, and

the *more* people we see doing a particular behavior, the more we will perceive the behavior or idea to be correct. The author presents the example of a laugh track – where people are more likely to laugh when they hear others laugh even if the television content is not especially funny. The author also cites the phenomenon of bystander inaction or "pluralistic ignorance" where when people are uncertain as to how to respond to a situation (often a potential crisis), they are more likely to do nothing when around other bystanders than if they were to witness the situation alone. People feel that if others are doing nothing to respond, that must be the correct behavior. The author explains that social proof is most powerful when we are witnessing the behaviors or choices of people who are similar to us (for this reason, advertisers often use "average person on the street" testimonials).

4) Liking: This refers to the idea that we prefer to say yes to the requests of people we know and like. An example of this phenomenon in practice is the use of Tupperware parties. We may feel pressure to buy the Tupperware because it is being endorsed and sold by friends. The author also cites an "endless chain" method for finding new customers, where companies may ask those who have used and like a product for names of others they know who might want to learn about it (the company then calls that person and says that xx person had thought they might be interested in the product – if that person is someone you know and like, you are more likely to buy the product than if the sales person were to cold call and try to make a sale). We are more likely to "like" those who are similar to ourselves. The author also mentions that we tend to dislike a person who brings unpleasant information, and inversely, we tend to like a person who brings positive information. Techniques used by marketers to facilitate "liking" include obtaining celebrity endorsements for products and praising or offering compliments to potential customers.

5) Authority: This principle refers to the idea that we tend to comply with the requests of those who we perceive to be in authority roles. Deference to authorities can often occur in a mindless way as a decision-making shortcut. Three key symbols of authority cited by the author include professional titles, clothing, and automobiles. The author also gave an in-depth description of the Milgram obedience study, which demonstrated that research participants were willing to comply with an authority figure's directions even when the actions appeared to cause extreme pain and suffering to other research participants.

6) Scarcity: This principle refers to the idea that people tend to give more value to things that are less available. Marketers employ this principle through techniques such as publicizing that there is a "limited number" of a particular item or that an offer or product is only available up until a particular deadline. The author explains that the scarcity technique also applies to information, and that limiting access to a message (such as by censoring it) causes individuals to want to receive it and to become more

favorable to it. The author adds that scarce items are most desirable when they have just recently become scarce, and when we feel we are competing with others to obtain them.

Main lessons learned/ applications to work in the international maternal and child health sector *(list no more than 8)*:

1) **Securing commitments can increase the likelihood that a person will do a particular behavior; use of "foot in the door" technique (asking for something small and then shifting to a similar but larger "ask") can ultimately shift self-perceptions around a person's role and level of public activity within society.**

2) **It is important to help people feel ownership over their commitments. People want to feel ownership and responsibility for the "terms of the contract." (negotiation can be a good thing).**

3) **Engage people similar to those in the target population in communication activities and to "market" a behavior or product. Ensure that health workers and communication messengers are "likeable" and perceived to be authorities on the topic.**

4) **Social norms and social proof are critical. Emphasize and demonstrate that other people within the community who are like them are doing a particular desired behavior.**

5) **The "rejection then retreat" technique can be effective in gaining compliance for specific behaviors. People may be more willing to accept a smaller "ask" when contrasted with an initial bigger ask.**

6) **It can be helpful to obtain referrals for other clients from satisfied users. When approaching a new client or community member, reference the friend/neighbor/family member who thought they might be interested in the service.**

Reader's professional opinion on the author's argument (perspective) *[i.e. was his/her point valid? How does the author's view compare to the opinions of CORE and its member organizations?]*

I found this to book to be a rich and interesting read. Key assumptions and findings were bolstered by a plethora of research studies. The key principles resonated with my own daily life and decision-making assumptions and shed significant insight into how professional compliance and marketing professionals operate. However, the vast majority of references and evidence cited were from the United States, and the text in general seemed geared specifically to a

Western/American audience (examples included telemarketing, post-Christmas sales, fraternity hazing, and Tupperware parties) and few examples focused specifically on health issues. It would have been useful to see more empirical evidence from other settings to see whether these principles resonate in less developed, low resource, and more communal/group-based societies as well. Certainly, we have seen NGOs use principles of commitment, social proof/norms, and liking (especially through use of contact referrals and featuring those who look and act like us in communication messaging) to promote specific health behaviors. Fewer examples came to mind where the consistency and scarcity principles have been utilized in the NGO health sphere.

Also, although this edition of the book was published in 2009, I was disappointed to see that there was little contemporary and emerging (post-2000) material incorporated in the text (although many of the historical research findings likely still resonate). There is also a strong angle to the book of how to prevent yourself from being unduly influenced, which seemed a bit less relevant to our work. It would have been interesting to hear more practical guidance on how influence techniques can be harnessed to promote positive (health) behaviors.

On a scale of 1(not recommend to others in SBC) to 10 (highly recommended for others in SBC) – how would you rate this book? **7.5**

Tags: persuasion, compliance, influence, commitment, authority, social proof, reciprocation, decision-making shortcuts, scarcity, marketing

Relevant Websites:

- http://www.influenceatwork.com/ (Cialdini's website)
- http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TRd2r7SjIWk (promo video for Cialdini)
- http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZB8AMUHq2HY&feature=related (Milgram obedience study referenced heavily in the "Authority" chapter)